

Illustration by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

One of the earliest references in Malayalam to the term 'India' that I have seen is in the late 18th century travelogue *Varthamanapustakam*. Written by the priest Paremakkal Thoma Kathanar, it is a detailed account of an eight-year-long journey from Kerala to Rome, via a variety of places, including Portugal. What is striking in that text is that there is a clear understanding that the entirety of the geographical region which traded with the countries of the West like Portugal was 'India', especially as there are astute observations about the terms and conditions that bound commercial activities of the time, regulating relations between countries.

A century later, we find multiple references to 'India' in O. Chandu Menon's *Indulekha*, a text that is often hailed as the first modern Malayalam novel. In contrast, it is relevant that while there is no mention at all of 'Bharat' or 'Bharatham' in the *Varthamanapustakam*, the few occasions when Bharatham is mentioned in *Indulekha*, it refers to the Mahabharata, which is usually referred to as such in Malayalam. It is very likely that it was in the nationalist, and humanist, poet Vallathol Narayana Menon's 1921 poem *Pora Pora* that one sees a clear first reference to India as 'Bharatha Devi', though the earlier poem *Mathrubhumiyodu* (1917) weaves in a maternal metaphor, imagining the nation as mother. Subsequently, while one sees the occasional use of the term 'Bharatham' in Malayalam to refer to India, it is by no means used generally in speech even today.

Apropos the recent controversy stirred up by the ruling dispensation in the country, we are returned once again to a situation where linguistic purity and authenticity are represented as the cornerstones of an authentic national identity. Yet as we know from Indian history, neither language nor nation, let alone the far more relevant category of region, are settled issues.

The formation of linguistic states did not offer a resolution or even a closure to the language question, and at least one of the reasons for this is that what can be seen as regional features of the Indian subcontinent do not fold neatly into the boundaries that have been demarcated for different states. The spillover can have different manifestations, with greater overlaps between certain parts of the broader region. For instance, Kasargod district in Kerala is culturally closer to parts of southern, coastal Karnataka than to, say, Palakkad, which in many ways bears greater affinity to Tamil Nadu. Malayalam, with its Dravidian base and strong overlay of Indo-Aryan elements from Prakrit and Sanskrit, and with a remarkable number of loan words that are routinely used as part of its vocabulary, has never been straitjacketed into bland homogeneity. In fact, from the latter half of the 19th century, debates about language use, origins and form have raged in Kerala. Earlier arguments were closer to the issue of Malayalam's linguistic origins—usually, if imprecisely, posed via the question 'Sanskrit or Tamil?' By the latter half of the 20th century, both scholarly writing that opened up ways to understand the complex structure of Malayalam, and the pushback from social reform movements led by the oppressed castes (the demand for recognition of 'Dalit mozhi') meant that Malayalam—and language itself—needed to be understood as internally variegated and possessing formal properties that have changed over time. In fact, anyone who knows Kerala will know

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